

Regarding the enviromental impact of AI, do the numbers that are usually spread around have any truth to them? And how do you answer when someone bring up other things that use up water and energy without sounding like a hypocrite?

Posted by u/HopKane • 0 points • 30 comments

I've seen a lot of statements going around different social media that said the use of AI use up a ton of water and energy and basically just bad for the enviroment and Ive never question them up until now. Like, yeah, it make sense that computation would be bad for the environment, and i get that people often exagerrate the numbers a bit. But after looking up the actual numbers and comparing them with other things, it doesnt seem to be that much?

Like the most common one is 500ml one but turns out that's for 20 to 50 prompts. Or google also released a statement that claims it only 0.20 ml per prompt for the median, which is way lower than what everyone else on the internet has been claiming.

Maybe someone more knowledgable can explain to me which numbers are real and how the enviromental impact really is. Because I feel like this is one of the view arguments with objectivity so ive also been spreading it around irl. but if it's actually not true then i would look like an idiot

if it is true, people often bring up meat, burgers, gaming and netflix as a comparison, how should i answer this?

Comments

u/DesertFroggo • 1 points • 2025-12-30 20:25 UTC

Even if you overlook the inaccurate data, you anti-AI folks also have to deal with the obvious hypocrisy of where you're coming from. Lawns, golf courses, beef, inefficient appliances, and bad insulation are one of the few many things that are wasting water and energy, but it's like you all just suddenly started caring about water and energy use when it comes to data centers. In other words, it's obvious you don't care about conservation in the abstract, but just as a convenient outlet for your hatred towards AI.

How many of you have actually, for instance, bothered looking into energy-efficient chest fridges to replace your standing fridge to conserve energy? My guess it probably almost none of you, because you don't care about saving energy if it means inconveniencing you. Many of you probably don't even know what a watt-hour is.

u/markaction • 2 points • 2025-12-30 18:15 UTC

As a society, we should demand the AI data center use a closed-water loop. That would solve the problem. Stop blaming AI here. It is people building the cooling mechanism on the cheap.

Solveable for AI. Less so for cheeseburgers.

u/fartremington • 1 points • 2025-12-30 17:48 UTC

Water usage is a typical go-to approach for anti-anything because you can easily hyper inflate numbers and make it sound scary. For example, a close looped system might use 500ml per second, but it's using the same 500ml over and over. Big difference depending how you frame it. Likewise water can be used for energy but it's just harnessing the flow of natural waterways. It's not being 'consumed' in the typical sense and turned into nothingness. It's considered a very clean reusable energy source but if you compute the amount of water in that natural current, it sounds scary.

In reality, everything uses a ton of water, but water doesn't turn into nothingness, it is just redistributed/recycled. That can be an issue (over consumption in a specific area). Another issue can be the waste/contamination of the water being expelled.

u/dobkeratops • 2 points • 2025-12-30 17:27 UTC

you can run AI locally,

my PC is aircooled, the water use per image and page of text is zero.

my electricity use remains reasonable (I dont want to spend a significant amount) and it does replace heating. There's a study been done showing that you probably do >100x more environmental damage by being alive for the time you drew a picture manually than by generating an image.

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41598-024-54271-x>

Any environmental argument is ultimately against *all* modern human activity.. if you really wanted to save the planet the most effective

action is dropping dead, the next is to quit all advanced activity (including art) and do subsistence farming.

Now having said that ever since the RAM price spike I have flipped toward defending artists against over-use of AI ,

There's an aspect here about the risk of all thought and creativity ending up centrally controlled. I end up using AI minimally.. some local chatbots to kill time and I got bored of image generation , I "picked up a mouse" and went back to practicing blender, 3d assets are more satisfying and more useful.

u/DisplayAppropriate28 • 1 points • 2025-12-30 10:16 UTC

Frankly, moral consistency is overrated. If your options are being a hypocrite or *consistently* doing nothing while the world burns, hypocrisy ain't so bad.

"Oh, you think human rights are important huh? You know you're using a device that's produced by human misery, right? How can you be against genocide while owning a smartphone sourced from Africa and built in China?!"

"Because *less suffering is good*, end of line."

u/HopKane • 2 points • 2025-12-30 10:32 UTC

I think it's different with your example because, 1 a phone is a necessity, 2 they are different non directly related cases.

But in cases like where the comparison is with other data center usages like streaming, social media, or other purely entertainment activities like gaming, hypocrisy is a valid counter argument. Like if you use a phone yet you make an argument to never use phone to other

You have the option to not stream netflix, or to not stream music, or to not browse IG or Reddit, yet you only prohibit other activities that bothers you? That just doesn't sit right. If I don't stream netflix for the day does that allows me to use AI then? Because if not then some people would be allowed to ruin the world more than me without repercussions. I feel like there's another angle I'm missing here because no way this many people would confidently do this amount of hypocrisy.

u/DisplayAppropriate28 • 0 points • 2025-12-30 10:56 UTC

Do the people arguing that social media is worse than AI *not* use social media? Are they all vegans? Do they not take showers?

No, on the whole they're feeding all the same fires that you are and also one more; their argument is "either fix all the problems or none of them", which doesn't help anyone with anything anywhere.

u/HopKane • 2 points • 2025-12-30 11:22 UTC

I don't think they're the one who prohibits other people from doing the thing that they're also doing.

It's not about fix all problems or none, my problem is if I prohibit people to use AI on the basis that it causes the world suffering, then why am I allowed to also cause that suffering.

u/DisplayAppropriate28 • 0 points • 2025-12-30 11:44 UTC

There's no universe in which consistently making all the bad choices is morally superior to making all the bad choices but one.

You can do more if you like, but I don't see why people that don't fucking care either way should be taken seriously on the matter.

u/HopKane • 2 points • 2025-12-30 12:07 UTC

Making all the bad choice but one is also not morally superior to making all the bad choices.

But personally, being a hypocrite is even more morally corrupt than not being one.

And it brings up another argument, that if I never had a problem with it in the first place then why do I have a problem with it now? Was it ever a problem in the first place?

u/DisplayAppropriate28 • 0 points • 2025-12-30 12:16 UTC

>But personally, being a hypocrite is even more morally corrupt than not being one.

I'd suggest you get your priorities straight, then.

Hitler saved the Jewish doctor that cared for his mother, would it have been better if he'd been consistent? This is an easy question for me, but apparently not for you.

u/HopKane •
1 points •
2025-12-30
12:33 UTC

What do
you mean
not for me?
No it would
not have
been better.
Him saving
the Jew is
also not
better. He is
still the
same
amount of
evil. Why
would you
twist my
words like
that?

That's what
I've been
saying, if
using
services by
data
centers is
causing the
world harm,
then me
and
everyone
else that
watches
netflix, or
stream
music, or
anything
else is also
causing the
world harm.

The
problem
with
hypocrites,
is that they
prohibit
other
people from
doing the
exact thing
they're
doing.

Now my
question is
are using
these
service
actually bad
then, if
people
didn't have
a problem
in relation
to energy
and water
usage
before

u/hilvon1984 • 2 points • 2025-12-30 09:25 UTC

You don't.

The problem with AI water consumption and environmental impact is not volume but location.

Basically most data centers are built in "cheap" locations. Because capitalism.

But that also means people living there are more likely then not poor, and thus already have precarious access to clean water and healthcare.

So even a moderate impact on water supply or environment in the area is making a bad situation into catastrophic one.

u/HopKane • 2 points • 2025-12-30 10:04 UTC

Well that would just make it seem like it's not an AI problem and more capitalism problem.

Data centers are also used for many other things that I enjoy like streaming and social media, which would make me a hypocrite if I brought it up. Is there any other aspect that I'm missing?

u/hilvon1984 • 1 points • 2025-12-30 10:38 UTC

>Well that would just make it seem like it's not an AI problem and more capitalism problem.

Yep.

The AI itself is not a problem. It is just a technology. If AI was still confined to research facilities helping astronomers find exoplanet candidates and help oncologist flag potentially problematic areas before they become tumors - nobody would complain.

And most problems usually associated with AI like job loss, or decline in quality of services because they are delegated onto AI and many others - are in fact Capitalism problems.

u/EvilChevalGames • 3 points • 2025-12-30 07:11 UTC

the way it works is if you want to inflate the numbers you stack the training with the inference and dont say you are doing that thats how you go from 1/5 of a tea spoon per 1000 words all the way up to 500 ml or worse (which is still off after inflation) ive even seen 1.5 liter per 100 word claim which is just plain dishonest

so , the real way to look at it is to separate training from inference(actually using it once)
training can lasts multiple months so if you run any facility for many months the costs add up , their still not terrible but there is a cost

thats like one big block of energy but then , the training ends and the usage begins

usage costs the electricity of running a single computer for maybe 30 seconds , think like the one you have at home , my somputer here has i thing a 200 watt power supply in it , maybe 300 watts , thats like 2 or 3 100 watt lightbulbs for 30 seconds , in a bigass data center the have larger computer so lets say 800 watts to 1100 watt

so all in all ,imagine in your house leaving 11 lightbulbs on but only for 30 seconds

so the whole problem here (essentiallt the big anti a.i bald face lie) is stacking the big block of multiple months of training on top of that 11 lightbulb x 30 sec

but here is the kicker

you are now magically doing that for EVERY single querie because people were not paying attention , like a magician making you look somewhere

so now every time you spend 11 lightbulu for 30 sec for 200 words , you also spend multiple months of energy even tough that was only spent once ever

so you multiplied that multiple month block by multiple millions of times

do you see how thats a VERY dishonest framing ?

here i just asked gemini for exact numbers

keep in mind that absolutely EVERY single anti a.i argument is dishonest to that degree all of em , the theft the a.i psychosis , the people losing critical thinking , ALL of it

all just because some artist are afraid of losing their jobs eventough they just recieved to best magical tool imaginable to actually do their job but instead of accepting to use a.i themself they make all this shit up so the can feel justified to punch other artists in the face whenever they catch the "being lazy thieves" , just because if they dont want to use a.i you shoudnt get to eighter

also as a gift if you read all thiis and you now feel a.i might actually be cool as shit you want to look up TRELLIS 2

its a new 100% free open source , extremely high quality 3d model generator dropped by microsoft 2 weeks ago ,its insane and you can just go download it and use it forever yourself to make cool ass shit

that means as 1 person you now have the creative power of an entire team at a big AAA studio like ubisoft or EA just last year that was completely impossible , now you are a 1 man army ,but your peers dont want you to be
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OX2P23W7TAA

u/EvilChevalGames • 2 points • 2025-12-30 07:12 UTC

As of 2025, the amount of electricity required for a single ChatGPT query is generally measured in **watt-hours (Wh)**, which represents energy consumed over time, rather than just "watts" (instantaneous power).⁽¹⁾

On average, a single ChatGPT query (using a modern model like GPT-4o) consumes approximately **0.3 watt-hours (Wh)**.⁽²⁾

To put that into perspective, here is how that energy compares to everyday activities and older models:

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Energy Consumption Comparison

Model / Activity	Energy Used (per query)	Equivalent To...
Google Search	~0.3 Wh	Powering an LED bulb for 2 minutes
ChatGPT (GPT-4o)	~0.34 Wh	Powering an LED bulb for 2.5 minutes

***ChatGPT (GPT-4 / Legacy)**|2.9 – 5.0 Wh|Charging a smartphone for 20-30 minutes|
|***High-Complexity AI Task**|10.0 – 40.0 Wh|Running a 1000W microwave for 1-2 minutes|